



Flight into Danger

Arthur Hailey

AIRCRAFT DISASTER stories always make powerful and suspenseful reading. If there is a master of this sort of chair-gripper, it is Arthur Hailey, author of the best-selling novel *Airport*. The following drama, written in the 1950s, was itself a best seller—expanded into a movie and rewritten as a novel.

While a plane in danger usually means turbulent weather, too little fuel or mechanical problems, the airliner in “Flight into Danger” is mechanically perfect; there is plenty of fuel and the weather is calm. Yet something—an unexpected calamity on board the plane—puts this craft and its 56 passengers in mortal danger.

The story is set in Canada. There are studio scenes of an airport passenger terminal, control room and tower as well as the passenger cabin and the captain's flight deck of a plane. Film “footage” of the exterior of a plane taking off and in flight adds to the realism.

Try to visualize as you read. Begin with a clear picture of the passenger lobby of the Winnipeg Air Terminal where George Spencer buys the last seat available on a chartered DC-4 headed for Vancouver.

Vocabulary Preview

EXUBERANT (eg-ZOO-buh-runt) full of high spirits; joyous
The fans were *exuberant* when their home team won.

EXTRAVAGANCE (ek-STRAV-uh-guns) something costly and self-indulgent

His buying expensive records was an *extravagance*.

PLACID (PLAS-ud) calm; tranquil; smooth

The *placid* waters of the lake gave it its name.

SOLICITOUSLY (suh-LIS-uh-tus-lee) with concerned attention; in a caring manner

The woman spoke *solicitously* to the ill child.

SIMULTANEOUSLY (sy-mul-TAY-nee-us-lee) at the same time

The alarm clock and the doorbell rang *simultaneously*.

STRIDENTLY (STRYD-unt-lee) in a loud and shrill manner; harshly noisy

The blue jay scolded *stridently* when anyone came near its nest.

DILUTE (dy-LOOT) to thin out or weaken

He was told to *dilute* the concentrate by adding three cups of water.

TOXIC (TOK-sik) harmful; deadly; poisonous

The leaves and flowers of some plants are *toxic* if eaten.

DIVERT (di-VURT) to turn aside

The police *diverted* crowds from the accident scene.

SLUGGISH (SLUG-ish) slow; lacking in vigor and energy

On cold mornings the engine was *sluggish* and often stalled.

Other Words You Will Need to Know

MANIFEST (MAN-uh-fest) a list of passengers and cargo for a particular flight

AFT rear section of an airplane

GALLEY (GAL-lee) kitchen of an airplane

EMETIC (ih-MET-uk) a medicine causing one to vomit

KNOT (NOT) a unit of speed for airplanes and boats

MAY DAY the international radio distress call

Characters

Aboard Flight 714:

THE PASSENGERS:

George Spencer, factory salesman, about thirty-five

Dr. Frank Baird, medical doctor, fifty-five

Seven Male Passengers

Two Women Passengers

THE CREW:

Captain

First Officer

Stewardess

At Vancouver Airport:

Captain Martin Treleaven

Airport Controller

Harry Burdick, agent for charter airplane flight

Switchboard Operator

Radio Operator

Tower Controller

Teletype Operator

At Winnipeg Airport:

First Passenger Agent

Second Passenger Agent

Flight into Danger

ACT ONE

FADE IN:

The passenger lobby of Winnipeg Air Terminal at night. At the departure counter of Cross-Canada Airlines a male passenger agent in uniform (First Agent) is checking a manifest. He reaches for P.A. mike.

FIRST AGENT. Flight 98, direct fleetliner service to Vancouver, with connections for Victoria, Seattle, and Honolulu, leaving immediately through gate four. No smoking. All aboard, please.

(During the announcement George Spencer enters through the main lobby doorway. About thirty-five, he is a senior factory salesman for a motor-truck manufacturer. Spencer pauses to look for the Cross-Canada counter, then hastens toward it, arriving as the announcement concludes.)

SPENCER. Is there space on flight 98 for Vancouver?

FIRST AGENT. Sorry, sir, that flight is full. Did you check with reservations?

SPENCER. Didn't have time. I came straight out on the chance you might have a "no show" seat.

FIRST AGENT. With the big football game on tomorrow in Vancouver, I don't think you'll have much chance of getting out before tomorrow afternoon.

SPENCER. That's no good. I've got to be in Vancouver tomorrow by midday.

FIRST AGENT. *(Hesitates.)* Look, I'm not supposed to tell you this, but there's a charter flight in from Toronto. They're going out to the coast for the game. I did hear they were a few seats light.

SPENCER. Who's in charge? Where do I find him?

FIRST AGENT. Ask at the desk over there. They call themselves Maple Leaf Air Charter. But mind, I didn't send you.

SPENCER. *(Smiles.)* Okay, thanks.

(Spencer crosses to another departure counter which has a cardboard sign hanging behind it—Maple Leaf Air Charter. Behind the desk is an agent in a lounge suit. He is checking a manifest.)

SPENCER. Excuse me.

SECOND AGENT. Yes?

SPENCER. I was told you might have space on a flight to Vancouver.

SECOND AGENT. Yes, there's one seat left. The flight's leaving right away though.

Arthur Hailey

19

SPENCER. That's what I want.

SECOND AGENT. Very well, sir. Your name, please?

SPENCER. Spencer—George Spencer.

SECOND AGENT. That'll be fifty-five dollars for the one-way trip.

SPENCER. Will you take my air travel card?

SECOND AGENT. No, sir. Just old-fashioned cash. ← *why?*

SPENCER. All right. *(Produces wallet and counts out bills.)*

SECOND AGENT. *(Handing over ticket.)* Do you have any bags?

SPENCER. One. Right here.

SECOND AGENT. All the baggage is aboard. Would you mind keeping that with you?

SPENCER. Be glad to.

SECOND AGENT. Okay, Mr. Spencer. Your ticket is your boarding pass. Go through gate three and ask the commissionaire for Flight 714. Better hurry.

SPENCER. Thanks a lot. Good night.

SECOND AGENT. Good night.

(Exit Spencer. Enter Stewardess.)

SECOND AGENT. Hi, Janet. Did the meals get aboard?

STEWARDESS. Yes, they've just put them on. What was the trouble.

*SECOND AGENT. Couldn't get service from the regular caterers here. We had to go to some outfit the other side of town. That's what held us up.

STEWARDESS. Are we all clear now?

SECOND AGENT. Yes, here's everything you'll need. *(Hands over papers.)* There's one more passenger. He's just gone aboard. So that's fifty-six souls in your lovely little hands.

STEWARDESS. I'll try not to drop any.

SECOND AGENT. *(Reaching for coat.)* Well, I'm off home.

STEWARDESS. *(As she leaves.)* 'Night.

SECOND AGENT. *(Pulling on coat.)* 'Night, Janet. *(Calls after her.)* Don't forget to cheer for the Blue Bombers tomorrow.

(Stewardess waves and smiles.)

DISSOLVE TO:

The passenger cabin of a DC-4 airliner. There is one empty aisle seat. Seated next to it is Dr. Frank Baird, 55. George Spencer enters, sees the unoccupied seat, and comes toward it.

SPENCER. Pardon me, is this anyone's seat?

BAIRD. No.

SPENCER. Thanks.

(Spencer sheds his topcoat and puts it on the rack above the seats. Meanwhile the plane's motors can be heard starting.)

CUT TO:

Film Insert: Four-engined airplane exterior. Night: The motors starting.

CUT TO:

The passenger cabin.

BAIRD. I presume you're going to the big game like the rest of us.

SPENCER. I'm ashamed to admit it, but I'd forgotten about the game.

BAIRD. I wouldn't say that too loudly if I were you. Some of the more exuberant fans might tear you limb from limb.

SPENCER. I'll keep my voice down. *(Pleasantly.)* Matter of fact, I'm making a sales trip to the coast.

BAIRD. What do you sell?

SPENCER. Trucks.

BAIRD. Trucks?

SPENCER. That's right. I'm what the local salesmen call the son-of-a-gun from head office with the special prices . . . Need any trucks? How about forty? Give you a real good discount today.

BAIRD. *(Laughs.)* I couldn't use that many, I'm afraid. Not in my line of work.

SPENCER. Which is?

BAIRD. Medicine.

SPENCER. You mean you're a doctor.

BAIRD. That's right. Can't buy one truck, leave alone forty. Football is the one extravagance I allow myself.

SPENCER. Delighted to hear it, Doctor. Now I can relax.

(As he speaks, the run-up of the aircraft engines begins, increasing to a heavy roar.)

BAIRD. *(Raising his voice.)* Do you think you can in this racket? I never can figure out why they make all this noise before take-off.

*SPENCER. *(Shouting, as noise increases.)* It's the normal run-up of the engines. Airplane engines don't use battery ignition like you have in your car. They run on magneto ignition, and each of the magnetos is tested separately. If they're okay and the motors are giving all the power they should—away you go!

foreshadowing of what?

BAIRD. . . You sound as if you know something about it.

SPENCER. I'm pretty rusty now. I used to fly fighters in the air force. But that was ten years ago. Reckon I've forgotten most of it . . . Well, there we go.

(The tempo of the motors increases. Baird and Spencer lean toward the window to watch the take-off, although it is dark outside.)

CUT TO:

Film Insert: Airplane taking off. Night.

CUT TO:

The passenger cabin. The noise of the motors is reduced slightly and the two men relax in their seats. Spencer reaches for cigarettes.

SPENCER. Smoke?

BAIRD. Thank you.

(They light up. Stewardess enters from aft of airplane and reaches for two pillows from the rack above.)

STEWARDESS. We were held up at Winnipeg, sir, and we haven't served dinner yet. Would you care for some?

SPENCER. Yes, please.

(Stewardess puts a pillow on his lap.)

STEWARDESS. *(To Baird.)* And you, sir?

BAIRD. Thank you, yes. *(To Spencer.)* It's a bit late for dinner, but it'll pass the time away.

STEWARDESS. There's lamb chop or grilled halibut.

BAIRD. I'll take the lamb.

SPENCER. Yes, I'll have that, too.

STEWARDESS. Thank you, sir.

BAIRD. *(To Spencer.)* Tell me . . . By the way, my name is Baird.

SPENCER. Spencer. George Spencer.

(They shake hands.)

BAIRD. How'd'do. Tell me, when you make a sales trip like this do you . . .

(Fade voices and pan with the Stewardess, returning aft. Entering the airplane's tiny galley she picks up a telephone and presses a call button.)

VOICE OF FIRST OFFICER. Flight deck.

STEWARDESS. I'm finally serving the dinners. What'll "youall" have—lamb chops or grilled halibut?

VOICE OF FIRST OFFICER. Just a minute. *(Pause.)* Skipper says he'll have the lamb . . . Oh, hold it! . . . No, he's changed his mind. Says he'll take the halibut. Make it two fish, Janet.

STEWARDESS. Okay.

(Stewardess hangs up the phone and begins to arrange meal trays.)

CUT TO:

Spencer and Baird.

SPENCER. No, I hadn't expected to go west again this quickly.

BAIRD. You have my sympathy. I prescribe my travel in small doses.

(Stewardess enters and puts meal tray on pillow.)

Oh, thank you.

STEWARDESS. Will you have coffee, tea, or milk, sir?

BAIRD. Coffee, please.

STEWARDESS. I'll bring it later.

BAIRD. That'll be fine. *(To Spencer.)* Tell me, do you follow football at all?

SPENCER. A little. Hockey's my game, though. Who are you for tomorrow?

BAIRD. The Argos, naturally. *(As Stewardess brings second tray.)* Thank you, dear.

STEWARDESS. Will you have coffee, tea, or—

SPENCER. I'll have coffee too. No cream.

(Stewardess nods and exits.)

(To Baird.) Must be a calm night outside. No trouble in keeping the dinner steady.

BAIRD. *(Looking out of window.)* It is calm. Not a cloud in sight. Must be a monotonous business flying these things, once they're off the ground.

SPENCER. It varies, I guess.

AUDIO:

FADE UP THE ROAR OF MOTORS

DISSOLVE TO:

Film Insert: Airplane in level flight, night.

DISSOLVE TO:

The aircraft flight deck. The Captain is seated on left, First Officer on right. Neither is touching the controls.

FIRST OFFICER. *(Into radio mike.)* Height 16,000 feet. Course 285 true. ETA Vancouver 0505 Pacific Standard. Over.

VOICE ON RADIO. Flight 714. This is Winnipeg Control. Roger. Out.

(The First Officer reaches for a log sheet and makes a notation, then relaxes in his seat.)

FIRST OFFICER. Got any plans for Vancouver?

CAPTAIN. Yes, I'm going to sleep for two whole days.

(The Stewardess enters with a meal tray.)

STEWARDESS. Who's first?

CAPTAIN. You take yours, Harry.

(Stewardess produces a pillow and the First Officer slides back his seat, well clear of the control column. He places the pillow on his knees and accepts the tray.)

FIRST OFFICER. Thanks, honey.

CAPTAIN. Everything all right at the back, Janet? How are the football fans?

STEWARDESS. They tired themselves out on the way from Toronto. Looks like a peaceful, placid night.

FIRST OFFICER. *(With a mouth full of food, raising fork for emphasis.)* Aha!

* Those are the sort of nights to beware of. It's in the quiet times that trouble brews. I'll bet you right now that somebody's getting ready to be sick.

STEWARDESS. That'll be when you're doing the flying. Or have you finally learned how to hold this thing steady? *(To Captain.)* How's the weather?

CAPTAIN. General fog east of the mountains, extending pretty well as far as Manitoba. But it's clear to the west. Should be rockaby smooth the whole way.

STEWARDESS. Good. Well, keep junior here off the controls while I serve coffee.

(Exits.)

FIRST OFFICER. *(Calling after her.)* Mark my words, woman! Stay close to that mop and pail.

CAPTAIN. How's the fish?

FIRST OFFICER. *(Hungrily.)* Not bad. Not bad at all. If there were about three times as much it might be a square meal.

AUDIO:

FADE VOICES INTO ROAR OF MOTORS.

DISSOLVE TO:

The passenger cabin. Spencer and Baird are concluding their meal. Baird puts down a coffee cup and wipes his mouth with a napkin. Then

he reaches up and presses a call button above his head. There is a soft "ping," and the Stewardess enters.

STEWARDESS. Yes, sir?

BAIRD. That was very enjoyable. Now if you'll take the tray I think I'll try to sleep.

STEWARDESS. Surely. (To Spencer.) Will you have more coffee, sir?

SPENCER. No thanks.

(Stewardess picks up the second tray and goes aft. Spencer yawns.)

Let me know if the noise keeps you awake. If it does, I'll have the engines stopped.

BAIRD. (Chuckles.) Well, at least there won't be any night calls—I hope.

(Baird reaches up and switches off the overhead reading lights so that both seats are in semi-darkness. The two men prepare to sleep.)

DISSOLVE TO:

Film Insert: Airplane in level flight, night.

DISSOLVE TO:

The passenger cabin. The Captain emerges from the flight deck and strolls aft, saying "Good evening" to one or two people who glance up as he goes by. He passes Spencer and Baird, who are sleeping. As the Captain progresses, the Stewardess can be seen at the rear of the cabin. She is bending solicitously over a woman passenger, her hand on the woman's forehead. The Captain approaches.

CAPTAIN. Something wrong, Miss Burns?

STEWARDESS. This lady is feeling a little unwell. I was going to get her some aspirin. (To the Woman Passenger.) I'll be back in a moment.

CAPTAIN. Sorry to hear that. What seems to be the trouble?

(The Woman Passenger has her head back and her mouth open. A strand of hair has fallen across her face, and she is obviously in pain.)

FIRST WOMAN PASSENGER. (Speaking with effort.) I'm sorry to be such a nuisance, but it hit me all of a sudden . . . just a few minutes ago . . . dizziness and nausea and a sharp pain . . . (Indicating abdomen.) down here

CAPTAIN. Well, I think the Stewardess will be able to help you.

(Stewardess returns.)

STEWARDESS. Now, here you are; try these.

(She hands over two aspirins and a cup of water. The passenger takes them, then puts her head back on the seat rest.)

FIRST WOMAN PASSENGER. Thank you very much.

(She smiles faintly at the Captain.)

CAPTAIN. (Quietly, taking Stewardess aside.) If she gets any worse you'd better let me know and I'll radio ahead. But we've still five hours' flying to the coast. Is there a doctor on board, do you know?

STEWARDESS. There was no one listed as a doctor on the manifest. But I can go around and ask.

CAPTAIN. (Looks around.) Well, most everybody's sleeping now. We'd better not disturb them unless we have to. See how she is in the next half hour or so. (Captain bends down and puts a hand on the woman's shoulder.) Try to rest, madam, if you can. Miss Burns will take good care of you.

(The Captain nods to Stewardess and begins his return to the flight deck. The Stewardess arranges blanket around the woman passenger. Spencer and Baird are still sleeping as the Captain passes.)

DISSOLVE TO:

Film Insert: Airplane in level flight, night.

DISSOLVE TO:

The passenger cabin. Spencer stirs and wakes. Then he glances forward to where the Stewardess is leaning over another section of seats, and her voice can be heard softly.

STEWARDESS. I'm sorry to disturb you, but we're trying to find out if there's a doctor on board.

FIRST MALE PASSENGER. Not me, I'm afraid. Is something wrong?

STEWARDESS. One of the passengers is feeling unwell. It's nothing too serious. (Moving on to the next pair of seats.) I'm sorry to disturb you, but we're trying to find out if there's a doctor on board.

(There is an indistinct answer from the two people just questioned, then Spencer sits forward and calls the Stewardess.)

SPENCER. Stewardess! (Indicating Baird, who is still sleeping.) This gentleman is a doctor.

STEWARDESS. Thank you. I think we'd better wake him. I have two passengers who are quite sick.

SPENCER. All right. (Shaking Baird's arm.) Doctor! Doctor! Wake up!

BAIRD. Um . . . Um . . . What is it?

STEWARDESS. Doctor, I'm sorry to disturb you. But we have two passengers who seem quite sick. I wonder if you'd take a look at them.

BAIRD. *(Sleepily.)* Yes . . . yes . . . of course.

(Spencer moves out of seat to permit Baird to reach the aisle. Baird then follows the Stewardess aft to the first Woman Passenger. Although a blanket is around her, the woman is shivering and gasping, with her head back and eyes closed. The doctor places a hand on her forehead, and she opens her eyes.)

STEWARDESS. This gentleman is a doctor. He's going to help us.

FIRST WOMAN PASSENGER. Oh, Doctor . . . !

BAIRD. Now just relax.

(He makes a quick external examination, first checking pulse, then taking a small pen-type flashlight from his pocket and looking into her eyes. He then loosens the blanket and the woman's coat beneath the blanket. As he places a hand on her abdomen she gasps with pain.)

BAIRD. Hurt you there? *(With an effort she nods.)* There?

FIRST WOMAN PASSENGER. Oh, yes! Yes!

(Baird replaces the coat and blanket, then turns to the Stewardess.)

BAIRD. *(With authority.)* Please tell the captain we must land at once. This woman has to be gotten to a hospital immediately.

STEWARDESS. Do you know what's wrong, Doctor?

BAIRD. I can't tell. I've no means of making a proper diagnosis. But it's serious enough to land at the nearest city with hospital facilities. You can tell your captain that.

STEWARDESS. Very well, Doctor. *(Moving across the aisle and forward.)* While I'm gone will you take a look at this gentleman here? He's also complained of sickness and stomach pains.

(Baird goes to a male passenger indicated by the Stewardess. The man is sitting forward and resting his head on the back of the seat ahead of him. He is retching.)

BAIRD. I'm a doctor. Will you put your head back, please?

(The man groans, but follows the doctor's instruction. He is obviously weak. Baird makes another quick examination, then pauses thoughtfully.)

BAIRD. What have you had to eat in the last twenty-four hours?

SECOND MALE PASSENGER. *(With effort.)* Just the usual meals . . . breakfast . . . bacon and eggs . . . salad for lunch . . . couple of sandwiches at the airport . . . then dinner here.

(The Stewardess enters. Followed by the Captain.)

BAIRD. *(To Stewardess.)* Keep him warm. Get blankets around him. *(To Captain.)* How quickly can we land, Captain?

CAPTAIN. That's the trouble. I've just been talking to Calgary. There was light fog over the prairies earlier, but now it's thickened and everything is closed in this side of the mountains. It's clear at the coast, and we'll have to go through.

BAIRD. Is that faster than turning back?

CAPTAIN. It would take us longer to go back now than to go on.

BAIRD. Then how soon do you expect to land?

CAPTAIN. At about 5 A.M. Pacific time. *(As Baird glances at his watch.)* You need to put your watch back two hours because of the changes of time. We'll be landing in three hours forty-five minutes from now.

BAIRD. Then I'll have to do what I can for these people. Can my bag be reached? I checked it at Toronto.

CAPTAIN. We can get it. Let me have your tags, Doctor.

(Baird takes out a wallet and selects two baggage tags which he hands to Captain.)

BAIRD. There are two bags. It's the small overnight case I want.

(As he finishes speaking the airplane lurches violently. Baird and the Stewardess and the Captain are thrown sharply to one side. Simultaneously the telephone in the galley buzzes several times. As the three recover their balance the Stewardess answers the phone quickly.)

STEWARDESS. Yes?

FIRST OFFICER'S VOICE. *(Under strain.)* Come forward quickly. I'm sick!

STEWARDESS. The First Officer is sick. He says come quickly.

CAPTAIN. *(To Baird.)* You'd better come too.

(The Captain and Baird move quickly forward, passing through the flight deck door.)

CUT TO:

The flight deck. The First Officer is at the controls on the right-hand side. He is retching and shuddering, flying the airplane by will power and nothing else. The Captain promptly slides into the left-hand seat and takes the controls.)

CAPTAIN. Get him out of there!

(Together Baird and the Stewardess lift the First Officer from his seat, and, as they do, he collapses. They lower him to the floor, and the Stewardess reaches for a pillow and blankets. Baird makes the same quick examination he used in the two previous cases. Meanwhile the Captain has steadied the aircraft, and now he snaps over a button to engage the automatic pilot. He releases the controls and turns to the others, though without leaving his seat.)

CAPTAIN. He must have been changing course when it happened. We're back on auto pilot now. Now, Doctor, what is it? What's happening?

BAIRD. There's a common denominator in these attacks. There has to be. And the most likely thing is food. *(To Stewardess.)* How long is it since we had dinner?

STEWARDESS. Two and a half to three hours.

BAIRD. Now then, what did you serve?

STEWARDESS. Well, the main course was a choice of fish or meat.

BAIRD. I remember that I ate meat. *(Indicating First Officer.)* What did he have?

STEWARDESS. *(Faintly, with dawning alarm.)* Fish.

BAIRD. Do you remember what the other two passengers had?

STEWARDESS. No.

BAIRD. Then go back quickly and find out, please.

(As the Stewardess exits Baird kneels beside First Officer, who is moaning.)

BAIRD. Try to relax. I'll give you something in a few minutes to help the pain. You'll feel better if you stay warm.

(Baird arranges the blanket around the First Officer. Now the Stewardess reappears.)

STEWARDESS. *(Alarmed.)* Doctor, both those passengers had fish. And there are three more cases now. And they ate fish too. Can you come?

BAIRD. Yes, but I need that bag of mine.

CAPTAIN. Janet, take these tags and get one of the passengers to help you. *(Hands over Baird's luggage tags.)* Doctor, I'm going to get on the radio and report what's happening to Vancouver. Is there anything you want to add?

BAIRD. Yes. Tell them we have three serious cases of suspected food poisoning, and there appear to be others. When we land we'll want ambulances

and medical help waiting, and the hospitals should be warned. Tell them we're not sure, but we suspect the poisoning may have been caused by fish served on board. You'd better suggest they put a ban on serving all food which originated wherever ours came from until we've established the source for sure.

CAPTAIN. Right.

(He reaches for the radio mike, and Baird turns to go aft. But suddenly a thought strikes the captain.)

Doctor, I've just remembered . . .

BAIRD. Yes.

CAPTAIN. *(Quietly.)* I ate fish.

BAIRD. When?

CAPTAIN. I'd say about half an hour after he did. *(Pointing to First Officer.)* Maybe a little longer. Is there anything I can do?

BAIRD. It doesn't follow that everyone will be affected. There's often no logic to these things. You feel all right now?

CAPTAIN. Yes.

BAIRD. You'd better not take any chances. Your food can't be completely digested yet. As soon as I get my bag I'll give you something to help you get rid of it.

CAPTAIN. Then hurry, Doctor. For Pete's sake, hurry! *(Into mike.)* Vancouver control. This is Maple Leaf Charter Flight 714. I have an emergency message. Do you read? Over.

VOICE ON RADIO. *(Vancouver Operator.)* Go ahead, 714.

CAPTAIN. We have serious food poisoning on board. Several passengers and the First Officer are seriously ill . . .

DISSOLVE TO:

The luggage compartment below the flight deck. A passenger is hurriedly passing up bags to the Stewardess. Baird is looking down from above.

BAIRD. That's it! That's it down there! Let me have it!

FADE OUT

END OF ACT ONE

Use w/ play

after Act II

→ script

"missing

scene"

ACT TWO

FADE IN:

The control room, Vancouver Airport. At a radio panel an Operator, wearing headphones, is transcribing a message on a typewriter. Part way through the message he presses a button on the panel and a bell rings stridently, signaling an emergency. At once an Airport Controller appears behind the operator and reads the message as it continues to come in. Nearby is a telephone switchboard manned by an operator, and a battery of teletypes clattering noisily.

CONTROLLER. *(Over his shoulder, to Switchboard Operator.)* Get me area traffic control, then clear the teletype circuit to Winnipeg. Priority message. *(Stepping back to take phone.)* Vancouver Controller here. I've an emergency report from Maple Leaf Charter Flight 714, ex-Winnipeg for Vancouver. There's serious food poisoning among the passengers, and the First Officer is down too. They're asking for all levels below them to be cleared, and priority approach and landing. ETA is 0505 . . . Roger. We'll keep you posted. *(To a Teletype Operator, who has appeared.)* Got Winnipeg? *(As Teletype Operator nods.)* Send this message. Controller Winnipeg. Urgent. Maple Leaf Charter Flight 714 reports serious food poisoning among passengers believed due to fish dinner served on flight. Imperative check source and suspend all other food service originating same place. That's all. *(To Switchboard Operator.)* Get me the local agent for Maple Leaf Charter. Burdick's his name—call his home. And after that I want the city police—the senior officer on duty. *(Controller crosses to radio control panel and reads message which is just being completed.)*

(To Radio Operator.) Acknowledge. Say that all altitudes below them are being cleared and they'll be advised of landing instructions here. Ask them to keep us posted on condition of the passengers.

SWITCHBOARD OPERATOR. Mr. Burdick is here at the airport. I have him on the line now.

CONTROLLER. Good. Controller here. Burdick, we've got an emergency on one of your flights—714, ex-Toronto and Winnipeg. *(Pause.)* No the aircraft is all right. There's food poisoning among the passengers, and the First Officer has it too. You'd better come over. *(Replaces phone. Then to Switchboard Operator.)* Have you got the police yet? *(As Operator nods.)* Right, put it on this line. Hello, this is the Controller, Vancouver

Airport. Who am I speaking to, please? *(Pause.)* Inspector, we have an emergency on an incoming flight. Several of the passengers are seriously ill, and we need ambulances and doctors out here at the airport. *(Pause.)* Six people for sure, maybe more. The flight will be landing at five minutes past five local time—that's in about three and a half hours. Now, will you get the ambulances, set up traffic control, and alert the hospitals? Right. We'll call you again as soon as there's anything definite.

(During the above, Harry Burdick, local manager of Maple Leaf Air Charter, has entered.)

BURDICK. Where's the message?

(Radio Operator hands him a copy which Burdick reads.)

BURDICK. *(To Radio Operator.)* How's the weather at Calgary? It might be quicker to go in there.

CONTROLLER. No dice! There's fog down to the deck everywhere east of the Rockies. They'll have to come through.

BURDICK. Let me see the last position report. *(As Controller passes a clip board.)* You say you've got medical help coming?

CONTROLLER. The city police are working on it now.

BURDICK. That message! They say the First Officer is down. What about the Captain? Ask if he's affected, and ask if there's a doctor on board. Tell them we're getting medical advice here in case they need it.

CONTROLLER. I'll take care of that.

BURDICK. *(To Switchboard Operator.)* Will you get me Doctor Knudsen, please? You'll find his home number on the emergency list.

CONTROLLER. *(Into radio mike.)* Flight 714, this is Vancouver.

DISSOLVE TO:

The airplane passenger cabin. Baird is leaning over another prostrate passenger. The main lighting is on in the cabin, and other passengers, so far not affected, are watching, with varying degrees of concern and anxiety. Some have remained in their seats, others have clustered in the aisle. The doctor has obtained his bag and it is open beside him. The Stewardess is attending to another passenger nearby.

BAIRD. *(To Stewardess.)* I think I'd better talk to everyone and tell them the story. *(Moving to center of cabin, he raises his voice.)* Ladies and gentlemen, may I have your attention, please? If you can't hear me, perhaps you would come a little closer. *(Pause, as passengers move in.)* My name is Baird, and I am a doctor. I think it's time that everyone knew

what is happening. So far as I can tell, we have several cases of food poisoning, and we believe that the cause of it was the fish which was served for dinner.

SECOND WOMAN PASSENGER. (*With alarm, to man beside her.*) Hector! We both had fish!

BAIRD. Now, there is no immediate cause for alarm or panic, and even if you did eat fish for dinner, it doesn't follow that you are going to be affected too. There's seldom any logic to these things. However, we are going to take some precautions, and the Stewardess and I are coming around to everyone, and I want you to tell us if you ate fish. If you did we'll tell you what to do to help yourselves. Now, if you'll go back to your seats we'll begin right away. (*To Stewardess, as passengers move back to their seats.*) All we can do now is to give immediate first aid.

STEWARDESS. What should that be, Doctor?

BAIRD. Two things. First, everyone who ate fish must drink several glasses of water. That will help to dilute the poison. After that we'll give an emetic. I have some emetic pills in my bag, and if there aren't enough we'll have to rely on salt. Do you have salt in the galley?

STEWARDESS. A few small packets which go with the lunches, but we can break them open.

BAIRD. All right. We'll see how far the pills will go first. I'll start at the back here. Meanwhile you begin giving drinking water to the passengers already affected and get some to the First Officer too. I'll ask someone to help you.

FIRST MALE PASSENGER. Can I help, Doctor?

BAIRD. What did you eat for dinner—fish or meat?

FIRST MALE PASSENGER. Meat.

BAIRD. All right. Will you help the Stewardess bring glasses of water to the people who are sick? I want them to drink at least three glasses each—more if they can.

STEWARDESS. (*Going to galley.*) We'll use these cups. There's drinking water here and at the rear.

FIRST MALE PASSENGER. All right, let's get started.

BAIRD. (*To Stewardess.*) The Captain! Before you do anything else you'd better get him on to drinking water, and give him two emetic pills. Here. (*Takes bottle from his bag and shakes out the pills.*) Tell him they'll make him feel sick, and the sooner he is, the better.

STEWARDESS. Very well, Doctor.

SECOND WOMAN PASSENGER. (*Frightened.*) Doctor! Doctor! I heard you say the pilots are ill. What will happen to us if they can't fly the plane? (*To husband.*) Hector, I'm frightened.

THIRD MALE PASSENGER. Take it easy, my dear. Nothing has happened so far, and the doctor is doing all he can.

BAIRD. I don't think you'll have any reason to worry, madam. It's quite true that both of the pilots had the fish which we believe may have caused the trouble. But only the first officer is affected. Now, did you and your husband eat fish or meat?

THIRD MALE PASSENGER. Fish. We both ate fish.

BAIRD. Then will you both drink at least three—better make it four—of those cups of water which the other gentleman is bringing around. After that, take one of these pills each. (*Smiling.*) I think you'll find there are little containers under your seat. Use those. (*Goes to the rear of plane.*)

FOURTH MALE PASSENGER. (*In broad English Yorkshire accent.*) How's it comin', Doc? Everything under control?

BAIRD. I think we're holding our own. What did you have for dinner?

FOURTH MALE PASSENGER. Ah had the bloomin' fish. Didn't like it neither. Fine how d'you do this is. Coom all this way t'see our team win, and now it looks like ah'm headed for a mortuary slab.

BAIRD. It really isn't as bad as that, you know. But just as a precaution, drink four cups of water—it's being brought around now—and after that take this pill. It'll make you feel sick.

FOURTH MALE PASSENGER. (*Pulls carton under seat and holds it up.*) It's the last time I ride on a bloomin' airplane! What a service! They give you your dinner and then coom round and ask for it back.

BAIRD. What did you have for dinner, please—meat or fish?

SECOND MALE PASSENGER. Meat, Doctor.

FIFTH MALE PASSENGER. Yes, I had meat too.

BAIRD. All right, we won't worry about you.

SIXTH MALE PASSENGER. I had meat, Doctor.

SEVENTH MALE PASSENGER. I had fish.

BAIRD. Very well, will you drink at least four cups of water, please? It'll be brought around to you. Then take this pill.

SIXTH MALE PASSENGER. (*Slow speaking, a little dull witted.*) What's caused this food poisoning, Doctor?

BAIRD. Well, it can either be caused through spoilage of the food, or some kind of bacteria—the medical word is staphylococcus poisoning.

SIXTH MALE PASSENGER. (Nodding knowledgeably.) Oh yes . . . staphylo . . . I see.

BAIRD. Either that, or some toxic substance may have gotten into the food during its preparation.

SEVENTH MALE PASSENGER. Which kind do you think this is, Doctor?

BAIRD. From the effect I suspect a toxic substance.

SEVENTH MALE PASSENGER. And you don't know what it is?

BAIRD. We won't know until we make laboratory tests. Actually, with modern food-handling methods—the chances of this happening are probably a million to one against.

STEWARDESS. (Entering.) I couldn't get the First Officer to take more than a little water, Doctor. He seems pretty bad.

BAIRD. I'll go to him now. Have you checked all the passengers in the front portion?

STEWARDESS. Yes, and there are two new cases—the same symptoms as the others.

BAIRD. I'll attend to them—after I've looked at the First Officer.

STEWARDESS. Do you think . . .

(Before the sentence is completed the galley telephone buzzes insistently. Baird and the Stewardess exchange glances quickly, then, without waiting to answer the phone, race to the flight deck door.)

CUT TO:

The flight deck. The Captain is in the left-hand seat. Sweat pouring down his face, he is racked by retching, and his right hand is on his stomach. Yet he is fighting against the pain and attempting to reach the radio transmitter mike. But he doesn't make it, and, as Baird and the Stewardess reach him, he falls back in his seat.

CAPTAIN. (Weakly.) I did what you said . . . guess it was too late. . . . You've got to give me something, Doctor . . . so I can hold out . . . till I get this airplane on the ground. . . . You understand? . . . It'll fly itself on this course . . . but I've got to take it in. . . . Get on the radio. . . . Tell control . . .

(During the above Baird and the Stewardess have been helping the Captain from his seat. Now he collapses into unconsciousness, and Baird goes down beside him. The doctor has a stethoscope now and uses it.)

BAIRD. Get blankets over him. Keep him warm. There's probably a reaction because he tried to fight it off so long.

STEWARDESS. (Alarmed.) Can you do what he said? Can you bring him around long enough to land?

BAIRD. (Bluntly.) You're part of this crew, so I'll tell you how things are. Unless I can get him to a hospital quickly I'm not even sure I can save his life. And that goes for the others too.

STEWARDESS. But—

BAIRD. I know what you're thinking, and I've thought of it too. How many passengers are there on board?

STEWARDESS. Fifty-six.

BAIRD. And how many fish dinners did you serve?

STEWARDESS. (Composing herself.) Probably about fifteen. More people ate meat than fish, and some didn't eat at all because it was so late.

BAIRD. And you?

STEWARDESS. I had meat.

BAIRD. (Quietly.) My dear, did you ever hear the term "long odds"?

STEWARDESS. Yes, but I'm not sure what it means.

BAIRD. I'll give you an example. Out of a total field of fifty-five, our chance of safety depends on there being one person back there who not only is qualified to land this airplane, but who didn't choose fish for dinner tonight.

(After her initial alarm the Stewardess is calm now, and competent. She looks Baird in the eye and even manages a slight smile.)

STEWARDESS. Then I suppose I should begin asking.

BAIRD. (Thoughtfully.) Yes, but there's no sense in starting a panic. (Decisively.) You'd better do it this way. Say that the First Officer is sick and the Captain wondered if there's someone with flying experience who could help him with the radio.

STEWARDESS. Very well, Doctor. (She turns to go.)

BAIRD. Wait! The man who was sitting beside me! He said something about flying in the war. And we both ate meat. Get him first! But still go around to the others. There may be someone else with more experience.

(Stewardess exits and Baird busies himself with the First Officer and the Captain. After a moment, George Spencer enters.)

SPENCER. The Stewardess said— (Then, as he sees the two pilots) . . . No! Not both pilots!

BAIRD. Can you fly this airplane—and land it?

SPENCER. No! No! Not a chance! Of course not!

BAIRD. But you told me you flew in the war.

SPENCER. So I did. But that was fighters—little combat airplanes, not a great ship like this. I flew airplanes which had one engine. This has four. Flying characteristics are different. Controls don't react the same way. It's another kind of flying altogether. And besides that, I haven't touched an airplane for over ten years.

BAIRD. (*Grimly.*) Then let's hope there's someone else on board who can do the job . . . because neither of these men can.

(*Stewardess enters and pauses.*)

STEWARDESS. (*Quietly.*) There's no one else.

BAIRD. Mr. Spencer, I know nothing of flying. I have no means of evaluating what you tell me. All I know is this: that among the people on this airplane who are physically able to fly it, you are the only one with any kind of qualification to do so. What do you suggest?

SPENCER. (*Desperately.*) Isn't there a chance—of either pilot recovering?

BAIRD. I'll tell you what I just told the Stewardess here. Unless I can get them to a hospital quickly, I can't even be sure of saving their lives.

(*There is a pause.*)

SPENCER. Well—I guess I just got drafted. If either of you are any good at praying, you can start any time.

(*He slips into the left-hand seat.*)

Let's take a look. Altitude 16,000. Course 290. The ship's on automatic pilot—we can be thankful for that. Air speed 210 knots. (*Touching the various controls.*) Throttles, pitch, mixture, landing gear, flaps, and the flap indicator. We'll need a check list for landing, but we'll get that on the radio. Well, maybe we'd better tell the world about our problems. (*To Stewardess.*) Do you know how to work this radio? They've added a lot of gizmos since my flying days.

STEWARDESS. (*Pointing.*) It's this panel up here they use to talk to the ground, but I'm not sure which switches you have to set.

SPENCER. Ah yes, here's the channel selector. Maybe we'd better leave it where it is. Oh, and here we are—"transmit."

(*He flicks a switch, and a small light glows on the radio control panel.*)

Now we're in business.

(*He picks up the mike and headset beside him, then turns to the other two.*)

Look, whatever happens I'm going to need another pair of hands here. Doc, I guess you'll be needed back with the others, so I think the best choice is Miss Canada here. How about it?

STEWARDESS. But I know nothing about all this!

SPENCER. Then that'll make us a real good pair. But I'll tell you what to do ahead of time. Better get in that other seat and strap yourself in. That all right with you, Doc?

BAIRD. Yes, do that. I'll take care of things in the back. And I'd better go there now. Good luck!

SPENCER. Good luck to you. We're all going to need it.

(*Baird exits.*)

SPENCER. What's your name?

STEWARDESS. Janet.

SPENCER. Okay, Janet. Let's see if I can remember how to send out a distress message . . . Better put on that headset beside you. (*Into mike.*) May Day! May Day! May Day! (*To Stewardess.*) What's our flight number?

STEWARDESS. 714.

SPENCER. (*Into mike.*) This is Flight 714, Maple Leaf Air Charter, in distress. Come in anyone. Over.

VOICE ON RADIO. (*Immediately, crisply.*) This is Calgary, 714. Go ahead!

VOICE ON RADIO. (*Vancouver Operator.*) Vancouver here 714. All other aircraft stay off the air. Over.

SPENCER. Thank you Calgary and Vancouver. This message is for Vancouver. This aircraft is in distress. Both pilots and some passengers—(*To Stewardess.*) How many passengers?

STEWARDESS. It was seven a few minutes ago. It may be more now.

SPENCER. Correction. At least seven passengers are suffering from food poisoning. Both pilots are unconscious and in serious condition. We have a doctor on board who says that neither pilot can be revived. Did you get that Vancouver? (*Pause.*) Now we come to the interesting bit. My name is Spencer, George Spencer. I am a passenger on this airplane. Correction: I was a passenger. I have about a thousand hours total flying time, but all of it was on single-engine fighters. And also I haven't flown an airplane for ten years. Now, then, Vancouver, you'd better get someone on this radio who can give me some instructions about flying this machine. Our altitude is 16,000, course 290 magnetic, air speed 210 knots. We are on automatic pilot. Your move, Vancouver.

Over. *(To Stewardess.)* You want to take a bet that that stirred up a little flurry down below?

(The Stewardess shakes her head, but does not reply.)

DISSOLVE TO:

The control room, Vancouver.

(The Controller is putting down a phone as the Radio Operator brings a message to him. He reads the message.)

CONTROLLER. Oh no! *(To Radio Operator.)* Ask if— No, let me talk to them.

(Controller goes to panel and takes the transmitter mike. The Radio Operator turns a switch and nods.)

CONTROLLER. *(Tensely.)* Flight 714. This is Vancouver control. Please check with your doctor on board for any possibility of either pilot recovering. Ask him to do everything possible to revive one of the pilots, even if it means neglecting other people. Over.

SPENCER'S VOICE ON RADIO. Vancouver, this is 714. Spencer speaking. I understand your message. But the doctor says there is no possibility whatever of either pilot recovering to make the landing. He says they are critically ill and may die unless they get hospital treatment soon. Over.

CONTROLLER. All right, 714. Stand by, please.

(He pauses momentarily to consider the next course of action. Then briskly to Switchboard Operator.)

Get me area traffic control—fast. *(Into phone.)* Vancouver controller. The emergency we had! . . . Right now it looks like it's shaping up for a disaster.

FADE OUT

END OF ACT TWO

ACT THREE

FADE IN:

The control room, Vancouver. The atmosphere is one of restrained pandemonium. The Radio Operator is typing a message. The teletypes are busy. The Controller is on one telephone, and Harry Burdick on another. During what follows cut back and forth from one to the other.

CONTROLLER. *(Into phone.)* As of right now, hold everything taking off for the East. You've got forty-five minutes to clear any traffic for South, West, or North. After that, hold everything that's scheduled outward. On incoming traffic, accept anything you can get on the deck within the next forty-five minutes. Anything you can't get down by then for sure, divert away from this area. Hold it.

(A messenger hands him a message which he scans. Then to messenger.)

Tell the security officer. *(Into phone.)* If you've any flights coming in from the Pacific, divert them to Seattle. And any traffic inland is to stay well away from the east-west lane between Calgary and Vancouver. Got that? Right.

BURDICK. *(Into phone.)* Is that Cross-Canada Airlines? . . . Who's on duty in operations? . . . Let me talk to him. *(Pause.)* Mr. Gardner, it's Harry Burdick of Maple Leaf Charter. We have an incoming flight that's in bad trouble, and we need an experienced pilot to talk on the radio. Someone who's flown DC-4's. Can you help us? *(Pause.)* Captain Treleaven? Yes, I know him well. *(Pause.)* You mean he's with you now? *(Pause.)* Can he come over to control right away? *(Pause.)* Thank you. Thank you very much. *(To Switchboard Operator.)* Get me Montreal. I want to talk with Mr. Barney Whitmore. You may have to try Maple Leaf Air Charter office first, and someone there'll have his home number. Tell them the call is urgent.

SWITCHBOARD OPERATOR. Right. *(To Controller.)* I've got the fire chief.

CONTROLLER. *(Into phone.)* Chief, we have an emergency. It's Flight 714, due here at 0505. It may be a crash landing. Have everything you've got stand by. If you have men off duty call them in. Take your instructions from the tower. They'll tell you which runway we're using. And notify the city fire department. They may want to move equipment into this area. Right. *(To Switchboard Operator.)* Now get me the city police again—Inspector Moyse.

SWITCHBOARD OPERATOR. I have Seattle and Calgary waiting. They both received the message from Flight 714 and want to know if we got it clearly.

CONTROLLER. Tell them thank you, yes, and we're working the aircraft direct. But ask them to keep a listening watch in case we run into any reception trouble.

(Another message is handed him. After reading, he passes it to Burdick.)